
LECTURE 07: STRESS MANAGEMENT

“Understanding Stress, Trauma, and Self-Care”

(Full Master Note — Expanded, Clear, Human-Readable, Exam-Ready)

1. What is Stress?

Definition

Stress is the **psychological and physiological response** to any event or situation (a **stressor**) that disrupts the body's equilibrium (balance).

Stress affects:

- **Mind** (thoughts)
- **Emotions** (fear, anger, worry)
- **Body** (heart rate, breathing, hormones)
- **Behavior** (avoidance, aggression, poor performance)

Key Characteristics

- Stress can be *real* (a danger) or *imagined* (a worry).
 - The brain activates the same response for both.
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1.1 Why Zebras Don't Get Ulcers (Sapolsky's Idea)

Robert Sapolsky explains differences between animal and human stress:

Animals

- Stress is **acute** (short-term)
- Triggered by **physical threats**
- Ends once danger is gone

Example:

A zebra runs from a lion → either survives or becomes lunch → stress ends.

Humans

- Stress is **chronic** (long-term)
- Triggered by **thoughts, fears, expectations**
- We replay events repeatedly → stress stays ON

Example:

Thinking about an exam happening next month can cause stress TODAY.

Mini Diagram

Animal Stress → Physical → Short → Survival Based → Ends Quickly

Human Stress → Mental → Long → Future Focused → Stays Active

Real-Life Case Example

Rina missed one deadline. Instead of letting it go, she keeps thinking:

“What if I fail the course? What if my parents get angry?”

→ Stress continues for weeks

→ Sleep disturbance + headaches

This is **human anticipatory stress**.

2. Is Stress Always Bad?

(Weiss, Levine, Seligman)

Not all stress is harmful.

2.1 Types of Stress

Type	Description	Example
Eustress (Good Stress)	Motivates, energizes	Excitement before a match
Distress (Bad Stress)	Overwhelms, drains	Fear of failing
Acute Stress	Short and intense	Sudden braking while driving
Chronic Stress	Long-term, harmful	Years of financial pressure

3. Psychological Modifiers of the Stress Response

These factors determine how strongly a person reacts to stress.

3.1 Outlets for Frustration

Healthy release mechanisms:

- Exercise
- Art / music
- Talking to someone
- Journaling
- Walking

Example:

A student frustrated with workload goes for a 20-minute run → stress decreases.

3.2 Sense of Predictability

Predictable events → less stress

Unpredictability → increased stress

Example:

Getting exam routines early reduces anxiety.

3.3 Sense of Control

Feeling “I can handle this” lowers stress.

Example:

Making a study plan increases confidence.

3.4 Social Support

Friends and family reduce emotional load.

Case Example:

People recovering from surgery recover faster when they have supportive family visits.

Mini Formula

More Control + Predictability + Support + Outlets = Less Stress Impact

4. PTSD (Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder)

PTSD occurs after experiencing or witnessing trauma.

Definition

A mental health condition involving intense, disturbing thoughts and emotions related to a traumatic event.

Trauma Examples:

- Road accidents
 - Violence / abuse
 - Natural disasters
 - Sudden death of loved ones
 - War
 - Severe medical procedures
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5. Signs of PTSD (4 Symptom Clusters)

A. Intrusive Symptoms

- Flashbacks
- Nightmares
- Unwanted memories
- Emotional distress when reminded
- Physical reactions (sweating, shaking)

Example:

Hearing a loud bang and suddenly reliving an explosion scene.

B. Avoidance Symptoms

Avoiding:

- Thoughts

- Conversations
- Places
- People
- Activities connected to trauma

Example:

Avoiding the road where a fatal accident happened.

C. Negative Changes in Thinking & Mood

- Negative beliefs (“I’m worthless”)
- Blaming self or others
- Persistent sadness or fear
- Loss of interest in hobbies
- Feeling emotionally numb
- Difficulty remembering parts of trauma

Case Example:

A survivor of robbery stops trusting all strangers and avoids going out at night.

D. Arousal & Reactivity Symptoms

- Easily startled
- Hypervigilance (always alert)
- Difficulty sleeping
- Irritability
- Angry outbursts
- Trouble concentrating
- Self-destructive behavior (speeding, drinking)

Children (under 6)

- Re-enacting trauma during play
 - Frightening dreams
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6. Identifying Inner Resources

Inner resources = personal strengths that help us cope.

Examples:

- Confidence
- Patience
- Emotional intelligence
- Social skills
- Optimism
- Problem-solving
- Faith or philosophical grounding

Example:

Positive self-talk (“I can handle this”) reduces anxiety during exams.

7. Myths About Self-Care

Myth	Reality	Example
Self-care is selfish	It prevents burnout	Taking a short break improves productivity
Self-care is temporary	Consistent habits make lasting changes	Daily 10-min meditation
Only for women	Needed for all humans	Men experience burnout too
Takes too much time	Even 5 minutes counts	Stretching, deep breathing
Anything soothing is self-care	Some soothing acts are harmful	Drinking alcohol ≠ self-care
Same for everyone	Personalized	One person likes journaling; another prefers exercise

8. Self-Care Strategies for PTSD & Stress

8.1 Physical Self-Care

- Exercise
- Yoga
- Breathing exercises
- Healthy sleep patterns

Example:

Watering plants every morning as a calming routine.

8.2 Emotional Self-Care

- Journaling
- Reflecting on feelings
- Forgiving self and others
- Healthy emotional expression

8.3 Mental Self-Care

- Reading something inspiring
- Practicing gratitude
- Learning new skills

8.4 Social Self-Care

- Talking to trusted friends
- Spending time with supportive people
- Joining groups or communities

8.5 Boundary Setting

Say “NO” to:

- Overcommitment
- Energy-draining situations
- Toxic people

Example:

Rejecting a late-night plan before an exam.

8.6 Professional Support

- Therapy
- Counseling
- Mental health workshops

Example:

Someone with recurring flashbacks attending cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT).

9. Memory Trick: “CARE PLAN” for Stress Management

C – Control (gain control)

A – Acceptance (accept what can’t be changed)

R – Release (remove emotional pressure)

E – Express (talk / journal)

P – Predictability (prepare ahead)

L – Limit stressors

A – Ask for help

N – Nourish yourself (sleep, food, rest)

10. Final Summary Table

Topic	Key Idea	Example
Stress	Body’s response to threats	Exam anxiety
Sapolsky	Animals = acute; humans = chronic	Zebra vs student
PTSD	Trauma-based disorder	Accident survivor
Intrusion	Flashbacks & memories	Nightmares after injury
Avoidance	Staying away from triggers	Avoiding hospitals
Negative Mood	Guilt, fear, numbness	Disconnection from friends
Hyperarousal	Sleep issues, irritability	Startling easily
Stress Modifiers	Control, predictability, outlets, support	Study routine reducing stress
Self-care	Healthy coping	Meditation, reading
Myths	Misunderstanding self-care	“Self-care is selfish” → false
